column layout, but the cart page uses a single-column layout.

You'll often use layouts across many different Razor Pages, so they're typically placed in the Pages/Shared folder. You can name them anything you like, but there's a common convention to use _Layout.cshtml as the filename for the base layout in your application. This is the default name used by the Razor Page templates in Visual Studio and the .NET CLI.

TIP A common convention is to prefix your layout files with an underscore (_) to distinguish them from standard Razor templates in your Pages folder. Placing them in Pages/Shared means you can refer to them by the short name, such as `"_Layout"`, without having to specify the full path to the layout file.

A layout file looks similar to a normal Razor template, with one exception: every layout must call the `@RenderBody()` function. This tells the templating engine where to insert the content from the child views. A simple layout is shown in listing 17.7. Typically, your application references all your CSS and JavaScript files in the layout and includes all the common elements, such as headers and footers, but this example includes pretty much the bare minimum HTML.

Listing 17.7 A basic _Layout.cshtml file calling `RenderBody`

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
    <meta charset="utf-8" />
    <title>@ViewData["Title"]</title>                ❶
    <link rel="stylesheet" href="~/css/site.css" />  ❷
</head>
<body>
    @RenderBody()                                    ❸
</body>
</html>
```

❶ ViewData is the standard mechanism for passing data to a layout from a view.